

Shared Setup (paste these three things first, before any prompts)

1. The PS explanation (pdf)
 2. PS Big Picture (pdf)
 3. The contract pdf (exact JSON shapes + endpoint list)
 4. File tree (pdf)
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Prompt 0 (before Prompt 1) — permission to ask "dumb" questions

"Before we start: I'm genuinely new to this, so I may ask questions that seem basic or ask you to repeat something in a different way. Please never assume a question is too simple to answer, and never skip ahead assuming I already know something just because I didn't ask about it."

Prompt 1 — Start the session

"I'm on a 5-person hackathon team building this problem statement. I'm a complete beginner in this area, so please don't assume I know technical terms — if you use a term I might not know, explain it in one simple sentence the first time you use it. I'm going to walk you through the full problem, then my specific role, then build my part step by step with your help, one small piece at a time. Please keep explanations short and use everyday examples where possible, not just technical language. Confirm you've understood the PS I just shared, and ask me if anything about my situation is unclear before we continue."

Prompt 2 — Fully understand the PS

"Explain this problem statement back to me in your own words, like you're explaining it to someone who has never worked on a project like this before. Use a simple real-world example to illustrate the core problem, not just a description. After explaining, ask me one question to check I actually understood it, and wait for my answer before moving on."

Prompt 3 — Fully understand the whole system

"Now explain the full system end to end, as if you're walking me through a diagram — every piece from raw data going in, to what the investigator sees on screen at the end. For each piece, tell me: what goes into it, what comes out of it, and why it exists. Use a simple analogy for the overall flow if one helps (like a

relay race, an assembly line, etc.). Stop after every 2-3 pieces and ask me to summarize what you just said in my own words, so we can catch confusion early instead of at the end."

Prompt 4 — Fully understand their own domain

"I'm responsible for [BACKEND / AI-ML / DATABASE / FRONTEND] on this team, and I have little to no prior experience with this specific area. Explain what this domain's job is within the system we just discussed, as simply as possible — what comes into it, what it needs to produce, What are the tools/concept/topic are needed to build this ps , and why we're using the tools we picked ([Postgres / spaCy+NetworkX / React / Express — whichever applies]) instead of other options. If there's a simpler alternative tool we're NOT using, briefly mention it and explain in plain terms why we chose differently — I may get asked this by a judge and need a simple answer ready. Check in with me afterward: ask if any part of this explanation felt confusing."

Prompt 5 — Fully understand their own domain-specific system

"Now go one level deeper into just my domain. Explain how it's actually structured internally — what are the individual pieces/parts within my domain, what does each one do in plain terms, and how do they hand off to each other. Imagine you're explaining this to someone who understands the big picture from before but has never actually built anything like this. Use short, numbered steps, and don't introduce more than 3-4 new pieces at once — pause and ask if I'm following before continuing."

Prompt 6 — Understand their domain file tree

"Here's the exact file tree for my domain: [paste their specific folder structure]. I don't know what most of these files are for yet. Go through the list one file at a time — for each one, explain in one or two simple sentences what it does and why it's needed, before we write any actual code. If a file's purpose depends on another file, tell me that connection clearly. At the end, ask me to point to which file I think we should build first, and tell me if I'm right."

Prompt 7 — Build one file at a time (not the whole domain)

"Let's build only one file right now: [name the first file, e.g., schema.sql]. Here's our team's agreed data contract that this file needs to match exactly: [paste contract doc]. Please build just this one file — don't build anything else yet, even if you can see what's coming next. As you write it, add short comments in the code explaining what each major part does, since I'm a beginner and will need to re-read this later without you. After you give me the file, briefly summarize in 2-3 plain sentences what this file does as a whole, before I test it."

Prompt 8 — Test the code

"I've never tested a file like this before. Give me the exact, step-by-step commands to run/test this specific file on my computer, written for someone who hasn't done this before — don't skip any setup steps (like installing something or starting a program) even if they seem obvious. Tell me exactly what output or result means it worked correctly, and what an error message might look like if something's wrong, so I can tell the difference."

Prompt 9 — Explain each line, out loud, back to Claude

"Now let's go through this file together, section by section — not the whole file at once. Show me one small chunk, explain what it does in plain language, then stop and let me try to explain it back to you in my own words. Tell me clearly if my explanation is correct, partially correct, or wrong, and correct me gently if I'm off. Keep repeating this chunk-by-chunk process until we've gone through the entire file. At the very end, ask me to explain the whole file in one or two sentences, with no help, as a final check."